Fictional Teaching Dataset: Household and Individual Survey Files

User Guide

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Table of contents

Table of contents 2
About the fictional teaching dataset 3
Structure of the fictional dataset 3
Relationship between the two data files 3
Variables 4
Missing values in the data files 5
Important note for users 5

About the fictional teaching dataset

This fictional dataset was created for teaching and training purposes. It contains entirely made up survey responses and is designed to resemble data from a household survey. It does not include information about real individuals or households.

The dataset is provided as two separate files: an individual-level fictional data file and a household-level fictional data file. The files consist of data on individual and household socioeconomic characteristics and keep the structure of realistic survey data, including variable names, variable labels, and coding. All data values and content are artificially created.

The two data files are designed to enable learners to practice common data analysis and manipulation tasks used in applied research without risks to confidentiality or data protection.

Structure of the fictional dataset

This fictional dataset comes in two data files: an individual-level file and household-level file. The individual-level records include information about each fictional respondent, while the household-level records include information about each household as a whole. Household and individual identifiers are included to identify records and show how they are related across the two files.

Relationship between the two data files

- The individual-level file is the main data file.
- The household-level file is constructed based on the individual-level file.
- Both files share a common household identifier (HHID), which allows records to be linked across the two files.

The table below summarises the main characteristics of each data file.

	Individual-level data file	Household-level data file
Data description	This is the original (base) file	This is the aggregated (non-base) file
Record structure	Each row represents one individual	Each row represents one household
Household Linkage	Each individual is associated with only one household through a HHID	Each household is associated with multiple individuals through a HHID

Shared HHID	Multiple individuals may share the same HHID	Each household will have a unique HHID
Numbers of individuals/households	30 persons	11 households

Variables

The individual-level file includes 9 variables, and the household-level file includes 5 variables. Variables in the individual-level file are suitable for individual based analysis, while variables in the household-level files are suitable for household based analysis. All the variables and their values are entirely fictional and do not contain information about real people or households.

The following table lists the variables included in the two data files and provides a short description of each variable. A full frequency count for each variable is available in the accompanying codebook.

No.	Variable	Description
Individual-level file		
1	HHID	Fictional household identifier
2	PERSONID	Fictional person identifier
3	HRP	Fictional household reference person (HRP)
4	SEX	Sex of fictional respondent
5	AGE	Age of fictional respondent (continues)
6	AGE_CAT	Age of fictional respondent (categorical)
7	RELATION_HRP	Relationship to fictional HRP
8	EDU_QUAL	Fictional respondent's highest level of qualification
9	EMPLOY_STAT	Fictional respondent's employment status
Household-level file		
1	HHID	Fictional household identifier
2	AGE_HRP	Age of the fictional HRP (continues)
3	REGION	Region
4	TENURE	Tenure
5	SAVINGS	Total household savings

Missing values in the data files

Both files consist of complete data for all cases, except for three variables in the individual-level file: (EDU_QUAL) “Respondent’s highest level of qualification”, (RELATION_HRP) “Relationship to HRP” and (EMPLOY_STAT) “Respondent’s employment status”, which contains missing values. These occur because the question was not applicable to some fictional respondents.

Different software packages represent missing values differently:

- SPSS and Stata: represent system-missing values as a single dot (.).
- R: represents missing values as NA. If you prefer working in R, you can import the SPSS files using the “haven” or “readr” packages. When these files are imported into R, SPSS missing value codes may be converted to NA, depending on the import settings.

Before starting analysis, check the frequency of variables to confirm how missing values (–9, NA) have been imported and handled in your software.

Important note for users

These fictional data files are completely made up. They do not include real individuals or households’ information. Any resemblance to real individuals or households is coincidental. They are intended solely for teaching, training and practice and should not be use in research or interpreted as findings from a real survey.

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